

duties" by the women (Driver); or when there is simply added to these the duties of performing the sacred dances and choral songs (Dillmann, Strack). The fact is, we do not know in what particular the service of the women consisted, but we do know that, whatever the nature of the service, it is described by the same term used for the Levitical service rendered in connection with the tabernacle.

The remark of Nowack (*Arch.* ii. 69, note) that we do not hear in the older accounts of women who serve in the sanctuary, suggests the inquiry whence the information contained in Ex. 38⁸ and perpetuated in 1 S. 2^{22b} originated. To regard it as haggadic, late Jewish fiction (Popper; Wellhausen, *Composition des Hexateuchs* u.s.w., 1889, p. 147) is out of the question. There is in late Jewish history no indication of a tendency to place women in positions of the cult; both the low estimation in which woman is held and the high estimation with which increasingly the ritual is regarded are against such an idea; the tendency is all the other way. It seems to me that the reference to the service of woman in the passage in Exodus is to something antiquated, something that had long passed even in the time in connection with which it is mentioned. It seems a futile effort to contend, like Dillmann and Keil, over the notion of time the participle **צָבָאֵת** conveys: Keil claiming that it does not imply that they had served there before the erection of the sanctuary, but only from that time forward they did perform service there; and Dillmann, that it does not mean that they served later, but that they served until now. It is the **צָבָאֵת** that will more readily render service here, yielding itself easily to the tense of the pluperfect; the passage can be rendered: "And he made the laver of bronze, and the base thereof of bronze, of the mirrors of the serving women which *had served* at the door of the tent of meeting." In accordance with this, it is not to be supposed that the **צָבָאֵת** contributed their hand-mirrors as a **תְּרוּמָה** (Dillm.), but on the analogy of Nu. 17²⁻⁵ (Eng. Ver. 16³⁶⁻⁴⁰), where the censers left by the Korahites, because of their sanctity through former use, are beaten out into plates for a covering of the altar, and are so turned into another sacred use, so here, the mirrors left behind by the women are put to another sacred service. It is very probable that in both cases we have to do with reminiscences, embodying Levitical traditions, attached to the sacred utensils of the sanctuary, which were in some cases termed **זָבָרִין** (Nu. 17⁵). And, although this notice is found in P and is probably a later addition even there, that does not preclude its being based upon very ancient tradition. The **אֵהָל מוֹעֵד**

in the Priest's Code is an elaborate affair and not historical, but E knows of an **מוֹעֵד אֱהָל**, tells us of its erection, and gives its name (Ex. 33⁷⁻¹¹), and also, as has been shown above, brings Miriam in close connection with it. In view of these facts, it is safe to say that the passages in Exodus and Samuel, though late themselves, are in perfect harmony with, and probably embody, an ancient tradition according to which, in early times, women held some official position in the sanctuary of Jahveh.

A side light upon woman's official position in the Jahveh cult comes to us also from the references in the Old Testament to the women singers. There are four distinct classes of these, one of which, the **שָׂרוֹת**, mentioned in passages like 2 S. 19³⁵ Jer. 31⁴ Ec. 2⁸ and Is. 23¹⁶, sang evidently only for social amusement, and may here be passed by with the mere mention. The other three classes will find the simplest explanation when considered in their relation to the religious cult.

(1) *The מְקַנְנֹת who chant the קִנּוֹת*. — Their official relation to, and prominence in, the cult of the dead have been considered above. See p. 137.

(2) The **מְבַשֶּׁרֶת**, *εὐαγγελιζομένη*, is mentioned by that name only in Ps. 68¹²⁽¹¹⁾, and the term is also applied to Jerusalem in Is. 40⁹; but the function of the **מְבַשֶּׁרֶת**, to announce and celebrate a victory by vocal and instrumental music and dances, finds frequent mention in the Old Testament (Ex. 15²⁰ Ju. 5¹ 11³⁴ 1 S. 18⁶ Ps. 68²⁶⁽²⁵⁾; cf. also 2 S. 1²⁰). That these choral dances were at least of a semi-religious character will scarcely admit of doubt. These were the "wars of Jahveh," and He Himself is **יְהוָה צְבָאוֹת**: the celebration of victory⁵⁶ must have partaken of a religious character. This becomes all the more evident from the religious element contained in some of these songs preserved to us (see Ex. 15²¹ Ju. 5^{3ff.} Ps. 68 Judith 15^{12ff.} 16^{1f.}). These facts have naturally enough led some to suppose that the particular service that the women according to Ex. 38⁸ and 1 S. 2²² rendered was the sacred choral dances. It is very probable that the term **צָבָא** may cover, but there is no reason to suppose that it exhausts, this part of woman's service.

(3) *Women Singers in the Temple Choir*. — Neh. 7⁶⁷ and the parallel passage in Ezra 2⁶⁵ furnish a more direct reference to woman's participation in public religious song. In Neh. 7⁶⁷, a register which has every appearance of having been drawn up under Zerubbabel

⁵⁶ "The Hebrew phrase for opening war is 'to consecrate war' (**קָדַשׁ מִלְחָמָה**), and warriors are consecrated persons." — W. R. Smith, *Rel. of Sem.*, p. 383.

and incorporated by Nehemiah in his Memoir (cf. Driver, *Introd.*, p. 513, and Stade, *Gesch.* ii. 98), the statement occurs that among the returning exiles were found "245 singing men and singing women." (In the parallel passage in Ezra, probably derived immediately from Neh., the number given is 200.) There is not the slightest reason to suspect the text, and Oettli's suggestion (*Kurzgef. Komm.*, *Die geschichtlichen Hagiographen*, Ezra, in loco) that the context would lead us to expect 'animals' viz. שׁוּרִים which, by a misunderstanding, was corrupted into מִשְׁרָרִים and to which was then added the feminine, is entirely uncalled for and too clumsy. Neither is it a happy suggestion that the function of these singers was secular. Is it likely that this company of religious enthusiasts, returning to a desolate home, had carried with them this number of singers for secular amusement? Rashi supposes that they furnished the music during the glad procession in the return from the exile. If this be not more ideal than real, their service would scarcely have ceased with their arrival at Jerusalem.

This reference to women singers, it seems to me, finds its simplest explanation in the supposition that not only did women in early Hebrew history participate in religious song, but that they furnished such sacred music as was used in sacred worship, and that, even in this later time, women still held positions in the temple choirs. There is some Jewish tradition to this effect. Schechter (*Studies in Judaism*, p. 316) makes the statement that "if we were to trust a certain passage in the 'Chapters of R. Eliezer,' we might perhaps conclude that during the first temple the wives of the Levites formed a part of the choir." (Unfortunately Schechter's reference is too indefinite for verification.) It is therefore altogether probable that when we read of music at the religious festive occasions, e.g. the dedication of the walls of Jerusalem (Neh. 12^{27 ff.}), it will best harmonize with the statement concerning those 'singing women' to suppose that they contributed their share of music as members of the singer's guild, the בְּנֵי הַמִּשְׁרָרִים of that time. We have here, therefore, an additional indication of women's official position in the Jahveh cult.